

In one line: React Native DevTools (Chrome DevTools frontend, default since **0.76**) debugs the **JS + React** layer of a **debug** build; everything below JSI — C++, Kotlin/Swift, the OS — is **Xcode / Android Studio** territory, and release builds are debugged with **profilers, logs and symbolicated crash reports**. Name the layer first, then the tool.

	RN DevTools	Radon IDE	LogBox	release-profiler	Xcode / Android Studio debugger	Instruments · AS Profiler · Perfetto	logcat · Xcode console	crash reporter
JS — your code, Metro bundle	Sources, Console, Network, Perf	breakpoints in the editor	errors, warns, red screen	JS functions (source-mapped)	—	JS thread as one busy lane	console.* → ReactNativeJS	JS stack + source map
React — component tree	Components React Profiler	inspector → source line	component stack	—	—	—	—	breadcrumbs, error boundary
Hermes — runtime, JS heap	Memory: heap snapshots	—	—	Hermes sampling	libhermes C++ frames	footprint (not objects)	—	—
JSI C++ — Fabric, TurboModules	—	sim/emulator in VS Code	—	—	LLDB C++ breakpoints	Time Profiler CPU samples	native aborts, DEBUG dump	NDK symbols, tombstone
Native — Kotlin/Swift, views	—	—	—	—	module code, view hierarchy	Allocations, Leaks, Hitches	Log.d · os_log/Logger	dSYM · mapping.txt
OS — process, threads, memory	—	—	—	—	—	System Trace threads, I/O	ANR, LMK, ActivityManager	exit reasons, MetricKit
works on a RELEASE build?	no — debug / debugOptimized	no (dev only)	no (dev only)	yes	debug build or attach	yes — Profile / profileable build	yes	yes — its job

React Native DevTools — what is in it

- Open: `j` in the Metro terminal, or Dev Menu → *Open DevTools* (Cmd/Ctrl+M Android emulator, Ctrl+Cmd+Z iOS Simulator, shake).
- Console** · **Sources** (breakpoints, conditional, logpoints, debugger;) · **Memory** (heap snapshots, allocation timeline) · **React Components** (edit props/state; “Memo” badge = React Compiler) · **React Profiler** (commit flame graph).
- 0.83: Network** (fetch, XHR, <Image>; headers, timings, previews, **Initiator** = JS call stack; *no* WebSockets, mocking, throttling yet) · **Performance** (JS, React tracks, network, User Timings on one timeline) · a **desktop app**. 0.84 dropped the in-app Perf/Network tabs; 0.86 added light/dark emulation.
- Docs’ own scope: React app concerns, *not* a replacement for native tools.

History · Radon · LogBox · logs

- Remote JS debugging** ran your JS in Chrome’s V8 — another engine, impossible with JSI. **Flipper**: removed from new projects in **0.74**, “unsupported”. 0.76 announced the end of log forwarding to the Metro terminal.
- Radon IDE** (Software Mansion): VS Code/Cursor extension running the Simulator/emulator *inside* the editor — editor breakpoints, inspector → source, network inspector, router integration, previews, replays. Free + paid.
- LogBox**: fatal = red screen; `console.error/warn` = badges, hidden while DevTools is attached; `LogBox.ignoreLogs([...])`; **off in release**.
- Native logs**: `adb logcat` (JS console = tag `ReactNativeJS`); Xcode console / `Console.app`. A module’s `Log.d/os_log` never reaches DevTools. Since 0.82 an **unhandled promise rejection** is a `console.error`.

Debugging a release build

- No DevTools, no LogBox in release. Dev builds are slow (`__DEV__` checks, no minify) — never judge performance there.
- debugOptimized** (Android, 0.82): C++ optimised + JS debuggable; ~20 → ~60 FPS vs debug. `npx react-native run-android --mode debugOptimized`.

- JS CPU in release**: `react-native-release-profiler` — `startProfiling() / stopProfiling(true)`, pull with `npx react-native-release-profiler --fromDownload --appId <id>`; open in Perfetto / SpeedScope / `chrome://tracing`.
- System**: Android Studio *Capture System Activities* (profileable) — watch threads `mqt_js` (JS) and the UI/RenderThread crossing 16 ms; Perfetto for exported traces. iOS: Instruments on the *Profile* config.
- Field data**: `PerformanceObserver` (stable 0.83) works in production — marks, measures, longtask, event timings to your analytics.

Example — symbolicate a Hermes JS crash

```
# android/app/build.gradle: emit the Hermes map
react { hermesFlags = ["-O", "-output-source-map"] }
# iOS "Bundle React Native code and images" phase:
export SOURCEMAP_FILE="$(pwd)/../main.jsbundle.map"
# prod stack says p01:132161 (bytecode offset)
MAP=android/app/build/generated/sourcemaps/react/\
release/index.android.bundle.map
npx metro-symbolicate $MAP < stack.txt
adb logcat -d | npx metro-symbolicate $MAP
```

Native: iOS **dSYM**, Android R8 `mapping.txt` + NDK symbols — upload all to the crash reporter **per build**; the JS map also **per OTA update**.

Traps

- ! “The map from yesterday’s build will do” — maps are per exact build/commit; a mismatched map gives confident, *wrong* lines.
- ! A heap snapshot shows the **JS heap** only — decoded bitmaps and native module memory are invisible there (use Xcode/AS memory tools).
- ! “DevTools shows nothing, the network call never happened” — WebSocket traffic and native-module HTTP (OkHttp/URLSession in a SDK) are not in the Network panel.

Remember

Layer → **tool**: JS/React = DevTools · C++/native = Xcode/Android Studio · release = profiler + logs + symbolicated crashes.